

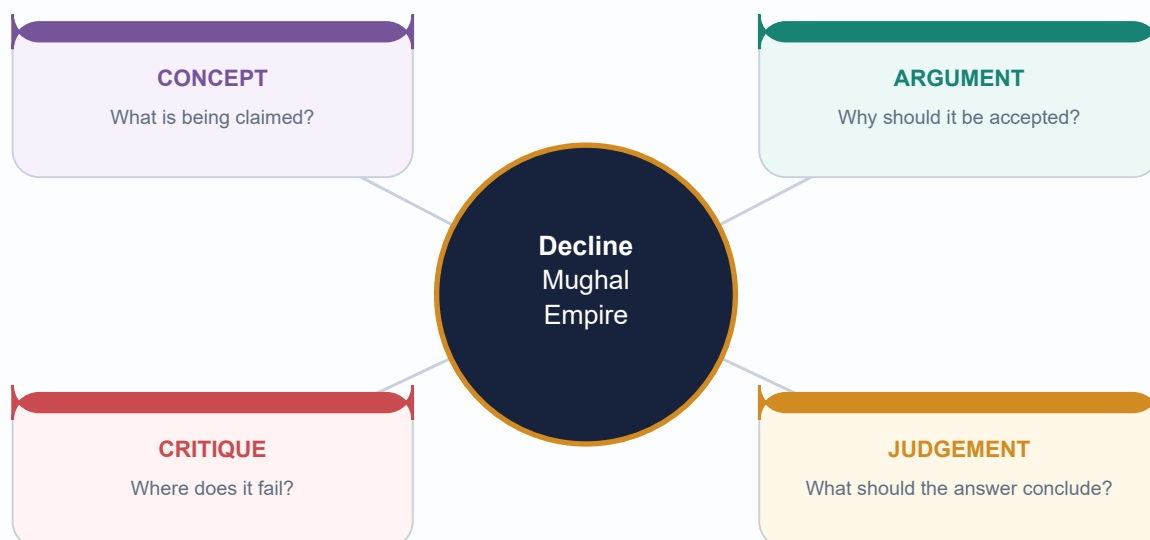
UPSC MODERN INDIAN HISTORY TOPIC PACKAGE

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) Complete Topic Package

Subject: Modern Indian History | Paper: GS-I

Sources: 01_Devote-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md + 01_Devote-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md

Practice is derived from explicit chapter traps, not generic placeholder questions



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Foundation · Core Foundation

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Subject: History (Modern India) · **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) · **GS Paper:** GS-I (also Prelims).

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

V

Dimension 1 Subject: History (Modern India) · Tier: Must-Do (foundation) · GS Paper: GS-I (also Prelims).	Dimension 2 Grounded in: Bipin Chandra, Modern India — Chapter I, "The Decline of the Mughal Empire".
Dimension 3 □ = from source book · □□ = inference / standard knowledge · □ = current affairs.	Dimension 4 Companion: advanced/01Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md. Chronology spine: 00Master-Chronology.md.

STATIC THEORY

- **Grounded in:** Bipin Chandra, *Modern India* — Chapter I, "The Decline of the Mughal Empire".

- □ = from source book · □□ = inference / standard knowledge · □ = current affairs.

- *Companion: advanced/01_Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md. Chronology spine: 00_Master-Chronology.md.*

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. = from source book · □□ = inference / standard knowledge · □ = current affairs.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Core Foundation

HIGH

Foundation · Mini-timeline

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Date	Event
☐ 1707	Death of Aurangzeb ; war of succession; decline sets in
☐ 1707–12	Bahadur Shah I — conciliatory but short reign
☐ 1713–19	Farrukhsiyar raised & deposed by the Sayyid Brothers ("king-makers")
☐ 1719–48	Muhammad Shah "Rangila" — long reign, empire fragments
☐ 1739	Nadir Shah sacks Delhi; carries off the Peacock Throne & Kohinoor
☐ 1748–61	Ahmad Shah Abdali's repeated invasions; Panipat III (1761)

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) → Mini-timeline

HIGH

Foundation · Snapshot & core idea · Part 1

GS-I Modern Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Foundation — the empire declined from strength, not sudden collapse.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA: RECALL MAP

Snapshot & core idea

V

Dimension 1 Foundation — the empire declined from strength, not sudden collapse.	Dimension 2 ☐ Aurangzeb's death in 1707 was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast emp
Dimension 3 ☐ Bahadur Shah I (1707–12) followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of w	Dimension 4 ☐ The Sayyid Brothers (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "king-makers" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had b

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
- □ **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
- □ During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
- **Foundation — external shocks exposed the hollowness.**
- □ **Nadir Shah** of Persia invaded in **1739**, defeated the Mughals at **Karnal**, sacked Delhi and took away enormous plunder including the **Peacock Throne** and the **Kohinoor** — a shattering blow to Mughal prestige.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
2. **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
3. The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
4. During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
5. **Nadir Shah** of Persia invaded in **1739**, defeated the Mughals at **Karnal**, sacked Delhi and took away enormous plunder including the **Peacock Throne** and the **Kohinoor** — a shattering blow to Mughal prestige.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Snapshot & core idea

HIGH

Foundation · Snapshot & core idea · Part 2

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

- **Ahmad Shah Abdali** (Nadir Shah's successor) invaded India repeatedly between **1748 and 1761**, further draining the empire and culminating in the **Third Battle of Panipat (1761)**.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. **Ahmad Shah Abdali** (Nadir Shah's successor) invaded India repeatedly between **1748 and 1761**, further draining the empire and culminating in the **Third Battle of Panipat (1761)**.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Snapshot & core idea

HIGH**Foundation · Key classification / data**GS-I Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Cause of decline	What it meant (Bipin Chandra)
☐ Weak successors	Post-Aurangzeb rulers were incompetent; wars of succession
☐ Faction & noble politics	Turani, Irani, Afghan, Hindustani groups; Sayyid "king-makers"
☐ Jagirdari crisis	Too many nobles, too few profitable jagirs (*be-jagiri*)
☐ Aurangzeb's legacy	Prolonged Deccan war and unresolved Maratha/Rajput conflicts over-stretched resources; historians dispute how much weight to give religious policy
☐ Agrarian/economic strain	Revenue pressure on peasants; declining central income
☐ Rise of regional powers	Marathas, Sikhs, Jats; autonomous provinces (Awadh, Bengal, Hyderabad)
☐ Foreign invasions	Nadir Shah (1739), Abdali (1748–61) exposed weakness

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Key classification / data

HIGH**Foundation · Study links**GS-I Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Study link: ☐ Regional successor states that broke away → basic/02_Indian-States-and-Society-18th-Century.md.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STUDY LINKS: RECALL MAP

Study links

V

Dimension 1 Study link: □ Regional successor states that broke away → basic/02Indian-States-and-Society-18th-Century.md.	Dimension 2 Study link: □□ Mughal jagirdari crisis roots → Medieval-Indian-History/basic/25Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md (continuity).
Dimension 3 Study link: □□ The vacuum enabled the English East India Company → basic/03, basic/04.	

STATIC THEORY

- **Study link:** □□ Mughal jagirdari crisis roots → Medieval-Indian-History/basic/25_Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md (continuity).
- **Study link:** □□ The vacuum enabled the **English East India Company** → basic/03, basic/04.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. **Study link:** Regional successor states that broke away → basic/02_Indian-States-and-Society-18th-Century.md.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) → Study links

HIGH

Foundation · Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

- **Aurangzeb died in 1707**; decline dates from the wars of succession that followed.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS): RECALL MAP

Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

V

Dimension 1 □ Aurangzeb died in 1707; decline dates from the wars of succession that followed.	Dimension 2 □ The Sayyid Brothers (Abdullah Khan, Husain Ali) were the "king-makers".
Dimension 3 □ Nadir Shah defeated the Mughals at Karnal (1739), sacked Delhi, took the Peacock Throne & Kohinoor.	Dimension 4 □ Muhammad Shah (1719–48) — during his reign Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became autonomous in practice.

STATIC THEORY

- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan, Husain Ali) were the "**king-makers**".
- □ **Nadir Shah** defeated the Mughals at **Karnal (1739)**, sacked Delhi, took the **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor**.
- □ **Muhammad Shah (1719–48)** — during his reign Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became autonomous in practice.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invaded India several times, **1748–1761**.
- □□ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. **Aurangzeb died in 1707**; decline dates from the wars of succession that followed.
2. The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan, Husain Ali) were the "**king-makers**".
3. **Nadir Shah** defeated the Mughals at **Karnal (1739)**, sacked Delhi, took the **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor**.
4. **Muhammad Shah (1719–48)** — during his reign Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became autonomous in practice.
5. **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invaded India several times, **1748–1761**.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

HIGH

Foundation · UPSC Traps

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

- Trap: The Mughal decline was **multi-causal and gradual** — do not reduce it to a single cause (e.g., "only Aurangzeb" or "only foreign invasions").

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MEMORY HOOK

Trap: The Mughal decline was multi-causal and gradual — do not reduce it to a single cause (e.g., "only Aurangzeb" or "only foreign invasions").

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.

CORRECT: It **fragmented gradually** over decades; the emperor remained a symbolic figure into the 19th century.

WRONG: Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.

CORRECT: He **plundered and left**; he did not annex the empire.

WRONG: The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.

CORRECT: They were **powerful nobles/king-makers**, not rulers.

WRONG: Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.

CORRECT: They became **autonomous in practice** while nominally acknowledging the emperor.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → UPSC Traps

HIGH**Foundation · Current link****GS-I** Modern
Indian History**NEWS TRIGGER**

□□ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne).** The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&-culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag □ when pegged to a specific verified news item.)

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of □ Current link.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → □ Current link

HIGH**Foundation · Mains angles****GS-I** Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Exam-ready treatment of Mains angles.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

□□ "The decline of the Mughal Empire was rooted in internal structural weaknesses; foreign invasions only exposed them." Critically examine.
□□ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority. □□ How did the political vacuum of the 18th century shape the rise of regional states and the eventual **British ascendancy**?

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Mains angles

HIGH**Advanced · Core Foundation****GS-I** Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Subject: History (Modern India) · **Tier:** Advanced (deeper understanding) · **GS Paper:** GS-I (also Prelims).

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

V

Dimension 1 Subject: History (Modern India) · Tier: Advanced (deeper understanding) · GS Paper: GS-I (also Prelims).	Dimension 2 Grounded in: Bipan Chandra, <i>Modern India</i> (Ch. I), cross-checked against Sekhar Bandyopadhyay, <i>From Plassey to Partition</i> — with the historiographical d
Dimension 3 ☐ = from source book · ☐ = inference / standard knowledge · ☐ = current affairs.	Dimension 4 Companion: basic/01Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md. Chronology spine: 00Master-Chronology.md.

STATIC THEORY

- **Grounded in:** Bipan Chandra, *Modern India* (Ch. I), cross-checked against Sekhar Bandyopadhyay, *From Plassey to Partition* — with the historiographical debate on eighteenth-century decline.

- ☐ = from source book · ☐ = inference / standard knowledge · ☐ = current affairs.

- *Companion: basic/01_Decline-of-the-Mughal-Empire.md. Chronology spine: 00_Master-Chronology.md.*

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. = from source book · ☐ = inference / standard knowledge · ☐ = current affairs.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Core Foundation

HIGH

Advanced · Mini-timeline

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

Date	Event
☐ 1707	Aurangzeb dies at Ahmadnagar; succession war among his sons
☐ 1707–12	Bahadur Shah I (Shah Alam I) — conciliation with Rajputs/Marathas/Sikhs
☐ 1713–19	Farrukhsiyar; Sayyid Brothers dominate; 1717 farman to the English Company
☐ 1719	Four puppet emperors in one year; Muhammad Shah enthroned
☐ 1724	Nizam-ul-Mulk quits the wazirat → founds Hyderabad ; provinces autonomous
☐ 1739	Karnal ; Nadir Shah sacks Delhi (Peacock Throne, Kohinoor)
☐ 1748–61	Abdali's invasions; Mughal power reduced to Delhi environs

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Mini-timeline

HIGH

Advanced · Snapshot & core idea

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Deeper — the debate over *why* the empire declined.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA: RECALL MAP

Snapshot & core idea

V

Dimension 1 Deeper — the debate over why the empire declined.	Dimension 2 □ Bipin Chandra frames decline as structural, not merely a matter of "bad kings": the jagirdari and agrarian crisis was central. The number of nobles
Dimension 3 □□ Historiography (context to know): Satish Chandra located the crisis in the jagirdari–agrarian system; Irfan Habib stressed the agrarian crisis (ove	Dimension 4 □ The nobility split into ethnic-factional blocs — Turani, Irani, Afghan and Hindustani (Indian-born) — whose rivalries paralysed the centre; the Sayy

STATIC THEORY

- □ Bipin Chandra frames decline as **structural**, not merely a matter of "bad kings": the **jagirdari and agrarian crisis** was central. The number of nobles (mansabdars) and their claims outran the supply of revenue-yielding **jagirs**, producing a scramble (*be-jagiri*) that turned the nobility inward against itself and against the peasantry.
- □□ Historiography (context to know): **Satish Chandra** located the crisis in the jagirdari–agrarian system; **Irfan Habib** stressed the **agrarian crisis** (over-exploitation of peasants driving revolts); the **Aligarh school** emphasised systemic economic strain, while a **regional/"revisionist" view** (Muzaffar Alam, C.A. Bayly) reframed 18th-century "decline" as a **shift of power and prosperity to the regions**, not universal collapse.
- □ The nobility split into **ethnic-factional blocs** — Turani, Irani, Afghan and Hindustani (Indian-born) — whose rivalries paralysed the centre; the **Sayyid Brothers** (Hindustani faction) epitomised how nobles, not emperors, now decided the throne.
- **Deeper — Aurangzeb's Deccan and the fiscal over-stretch.**
- □ Aurangzeb's prolonged **Deccan campaigns** over-extended the empire militarily and financially and failed to extinguish Maratha resistance. □□ The relative importance of Rajput conflict and religious policy remains debated and should not be used as a single-cause explanation.
- □ Under weak successors the **provincial governors** (Bengal under Murshid Quli Khan, Awadh under Saadat Khan, Hyderabad under the Nizam) founded effectively **hereditary, autonomous states** while still coining money and reading the *khutba* in the emperor's name — a legal fiction of unity over a real fragmentation.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Bipin Chandra frames decline as **structural**, not merely a matter of "bad kings": the **jagirdari and agrarian crisis** was central. The number of nobles (mansabdars) and their claims outran the supply of revenue-yielding **jagirs**, producing a scramble (*be-jagiri*) that turned the nobility inward against itself and against the peasantry.
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MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Snapshot & core idea

HIGH**Advanced · Key classification / data**

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

Interpretation	Emphasis	Associated with
□ Jagirdari crisis	Nobles greater than available jagirs (*be-jagiri*); factionalism	Satish Chandra / Bipin Chandra
□□ Agrarian crisis	Over-taxation → zamindar/peasant revolts	Irfan Habib (Aligarh)
□□ Cultural/personal decline thesis	Courtly morality, rulers' character or religious policy	Older interpretation; insufficient without fiscal, agrarian and regional evidence
□□ Regional "revisionist" view	18th c. = redistribution of power to regions, not collapse	Muzaffar Alam, C.A. Bayly
□ Personal/successor factor	Weak rulers, wars of succession, king-making nobles	Bipin Chandra

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Key classification / data

HIGH

Advanced · Study links

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Study link: □ Successor states (Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad, Marathas, Sikhs, Jats) → advanced/02.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STUDY LINKS: RECALL MAP

Study links

V

Dimension 1 Study link: □ Successor states (Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad, Marathas, Sikhs, Jats) → advanced/02.	Dimension 2 Study link: □□ The 1717 farman to the English Company → advanced/03 (European settlements) & advanced/04 (Bengal conquest).
Dimension 3 Study link: □□ Compare jagirdari crisis with the Medieval analysis → Medieval-Indian-History/advanced/25.	

STATIC THEORY

- **Study link:** □□ The **1717 farman** to the English Company → advanced/03 (European settlements) & advanced/04 (Bengal conquest).

- **Study link:** □□ Compare jagirdari crisis with the **Medieval** analysis → Medieval-Indian-History/advanced/25.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. **Study link:** Successor states (Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad, Marathas, Sikhs, Jats) → advanced/02.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Study links

HIGH

Advanced · Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ **1717 farman** (Farrukhsiyar) gave the English Company duty-free trade in Bengal — a major cause of later friction.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS): RECALL MAP

Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

V

Dimension 1 ☐ 1717 farman (Farrukhsiyar) gave the English Company duty-free trade in Bengal — a major cause of later friction.	Dimension 2 ☐ Murshid Quli Khan (Bengal), Saadat Khan/Burhan-ul-Mulk (Awadh), Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah (Hyderabad, 1724) founded autonomous provincial dynasties.
Dimension 3 ☐ Karnal (1739) — Nadir Shah's victory; Delhi sacked; Peacock Throne & Kohinoor taken.	Dimension 4 ☐ Sayyid Brothers = Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali (the "king-makers").

STATIC THEORY

- ☐ **Murshid Quli Khan** (Bengal), **Saadat Khan/Burhan-ul-Mulk** (Awadh), **Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah** (Hyderabad, 1724) founded autonomous provincial dynasties.
- ☐ **Karnal (1739)** — Nadir Shah's victory; Delhi sacked; **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor** taken.
- ☐ **Sayyid Brothers** = Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali (the "king-makers").
- ☐ Historiographic labels to deploy: **jagirdari crisis** (Satish Chandra), **agrarian crisis** (Irfan Habib), **regional revisionism** (Alam/Bayly).

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. **1717 farman** (Farrukhsiyar) gave the English Company duty-free trade in Bengal — a major cause of later friction.
2. **Murshid Quli Khan** (Bengal), **Saadat Khan/Burhan-ul-Mulk** (Awadh), **Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah** (Hyderabad, 1724) founded autonomous provincial dynasties.
3. **Karnal (1739)** — Nadir Shah's victory; Delhi sacked; **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor** taken.
4. **Sayyid Brothers** = Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali (the "king-makers").

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

HIGH

Advanced · UPSC Traps

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

- ☐ Trap: Distinguish "**decline of the empire**" (central authority) from "**decline of the economy/regions.**" The revisionist point is that many *regions prospered* even as the *centre* collapsed.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MEMORY HOOK

Trap: Distinguish "decline of the empire" (central authority) from "decline of the economy/regions." The revisionist point is that many *regions prospered* even as the *centre* collapsed.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant.

CORRECT: Regional economies and states (Bengal, Awadh, Marathas) were often **vibrant**; "decline" was of the *centre*.

WRONG: The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption.

CORRECT: It was a **structural mismatch** between the number of claimants and revenue-yielding assignments.

WRONG: Provincial governors declared full independence.

CORRECT: They kept the **legal fiction** of Mughal sovereignty (coins/khutba in the emperor's name).

WRONG: Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline.

CORRECT: They **accelerated and exposed** a decline that was already structural.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → UPSC Traps

HIGH**Advanced · ☐ Current link**GS-I Modern
Indian History**NEWS TRIGGER**

☐ ☐ **Cultural repatriation & the Kohinoor debate.** The Kohinoor (looted by Nadir Shah in 1739, later British crown jewel) and the Peacock Throne recur in India's periodic demands for the return of looted heritage. Relevance: an 18th-century plunder story that feeds present GS-2 cultural-diplomacy and GS-1 art-&-culture debates. (*Escalate to ☐ when tied to a specific verified news peg.*)

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of ☐ Current link.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → ☐ Current link

HIGH**Advanced · Mains angles**GS-I Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Exam-ready treatment of Mains angles.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

□□ "The eighteenth century was less a 'dark age' of decline than an age of political decentralisation and regional reordering." Critically discuss with reference to the historiographical debate. □□ Examine the **jagirdari–agrarian crisis** as the structural core of Mughal decline, distinguishing it from personal and external factors. □□ How did the autonomy of the successor states create both the opportunity and the instruments for **British expansion**?

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Mains angles

HIGH**Advanced · □ Historiography note (PYQ-gap)**GS-I Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Exam-ready treatment of □ Historiography note (PYQ-gap).

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

□□ UPSC (GS-1 & History optional) repeatedly probes the **"eighteenth-century debate."** Be ready to name and contrast: **Jadunath Sarkar** (moral/character decline, "Aurangzeb's religious policy"), **Satish Chandra** (jagirdari crisis), **Irfan Habib** (agrarian crisis), and the **revisionists Muzaffar Alam & C.A. Bayly** (regional continuity/prosperity). This "why did the Mughal Empire decline?" framework is a high-yield analytical template.

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → □ Historiography note
(PYQ-gap)

HIGH**Current-Affairs Verification Note**GS-I Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

A live February-August 2026 scan was performed. No unverified headline is inserted. The source chapter's dated current anchor is retained where it is already verified.

STATIC THEORY

- Static concepts remain the evidentiary base.
- Current affairs are used only when the conceptual linkage is direct.
- No-current-item is preferable to a fabricated or weakly sourced linkage.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) → Current application

HIGH

Topic-Specific MCQ Loop 1

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Each question is generated from an explicit source-chapter trap and explanation.

STATIC THEORY

- Q1. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "The empire collapsed immediately in 1707."?

- A. It **fragmented gradually** over decades; the emperor remained a symbolic figure into the 19th century.

- B. The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.

- C. Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.

- D. The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.

- ANSWER: A - It **fragmented gradually** over decades; the emperor remained a symbolic figure into the 19th century.

- Q2. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India."?

- A. Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.

- B. He **plundered and left**; he did not annex the empire.

- C. The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.

- D. Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.

- ANSWER: B - He **plundered and left**; he did not annex the empire.

- Q3. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "The Sayyid Brothers were emperors."?

- A. The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.

- B. Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.

- C. They were **powerful nobles/king-makers**, not rulers.

- D. 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant.

- ANSWER: C - They were **powerful nobles/king-makers**, not rulers.

- Q4. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence."?

- A. Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.

- B. 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant.

- C. The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption.

- D. They became **autonomous in practice** while nominally acknowledging the emperor.

- ANSWER: D - They became **autonomous in practice** while nominally acknowledging the emperor.

MEMORY HOOK

Resolve the misconception before memorising the fact.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) -> Source-grounded practice

HIGH**Topic-Specific MCQ Loop 2****GS-I Modern
Indian History****INTRO & ORIGIN**

Each question is generated from an explicit source-chapter trap and explanation.

STATIC THEORY

- Q5. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant."?

- A. Regional economies and states (Bengal, Awadh, Marathas) were often **vibrant**; "decline" was of the *centre*.
- B. 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant.
- C. The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption.
- D. Provincial governors declared full independence.

- ANSWER: A - Regional economies and states (Bengal, Awadh, Marathas) were often **vibrant**; "decline" was of the *centre*.

- Q6. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption."?

- A. The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption.
- B. It was a **structural mismatch** between the number of claimants and revenue-yielding assignments.
- C. Provincial governors declared full independence.
- D. Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline.

- ANSWER: B - It was a **structural mismatch** between the number of claimants and revenue-yielding assignments.

- Q7. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Provincial governors declared full independence."?

- A. Provincial governors declared full independence.
- B. Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline.
- C. They kept the **legal fiction** of Mughal sovereignty (coins/khutba in the emperor's name).
- D. The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.

- ANSWER: C - They kept the **legal fiction** of Mughal sovereignty (coins/khutba in the emperor's name).

- Q8. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline."?

- A. Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline.
- B. The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.
- C. Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.
- D. They **accelerated and exposed** a decline that was already structural.

- ANSWER: D - They **accelerated and exposed** a decline that was already structural.

MEMORY HOOK

Resolve the misconception before memorising the fact.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) -> Source-grounded practice

HIGH

Solved 10-Mark PracticeGS-I Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Explain The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) with reference to its concepts, applications and limitations.

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE**1. Concept**

Define the exact scope and terminology.

V

2. Core analysis

Organise the source content into two or three dimensions.

V

3. Evidence

Use the chapter's India-centric examples or chronology.

V

4. Critical layer

Add traps, limitations, counter-view or implementation constraints.

V

5. Judgement

Conclude in direct response to the directive.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
- □ **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
- □ During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
- □ **Nadir Shah** of Persia invaded in **1739**, defeated the Mughals at **Karnal**, sacked Delhi and took away enormous plunder including the **Peacock Throne** and the **Kohinoor** — a shattering blow to Mughal prestige.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** (Nadir Shah's successor) invaded India repeatedly between **1748 and 1761**, further draining the empire and culminating in the **Third Battle of Panipat (1761)**.
- □ **Aurangzeb died in 1707**; decline dates from the wars of succession that followed.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan, Husain Ali) were the "**king-makers**".
- □ **Nadir Shah** defeated the Mughals at **Karnal (1739)**, sacked Delhi, took the **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor**.
- □ **Muhammad Shah (1719–48)** — during his reign Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became autonomous in practice.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invaded India several times, **1748–1761**.
- □□ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.
- □□ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne)**. The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag □ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
- □□ "The decline of the Mughal Empire was rooted in internal structural weaknesses; foreign invasions only exposed them." Critically examine.
- □□ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.

MAINS ANGLE

These are model content points; arrange them into paragraphs rather than reproducing a list.

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) -> 10-mark answer

HIGH

Solved 15-Mark Practice

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Analyse The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) with reference to its concepts, applications and limitations.

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE**1. Concept**

Define the exact scope and terminology.

V

2. Core analysis

Organise the source content into two or three dimensions.

V

3. Evidence

Use the chapter's India-centric examples or chronology.

V

4. Critical layer

Add traps, limitations, counter-view or implementation constraints.

V

5. Judgement

Conclude in direct response to the directive.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
- □ **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
- □ During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
- □ **Nadir Shah** of Persia invaded in **1739**, defeated the Mughals at **Karnal**, sacked Delhi and took away enormous plunder including the **Peacock Throne** and the **Kohinoor** — a shattering blow to Mughal prestige.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** (Nadir Shah's successor) invaded India repeatedly between **1748 and 1761**, further draining the empire and culminating in the **Third Battle of Panipat (1761)**.
- □ **Aurangzeb died in 1707**; decline dates from the wars of succession that followed.
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- □ **Nadir Shah** defeated the Mughals at **Karnal (1739)**, sacked Delhi, took the **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor**.
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- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invaded India several times, **1748–1761**.
- □□ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.
- □□ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne)**. The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag □ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
- □□ "The decline of the Mughal Empire was rooted in internal structural weaknesses; foreign invasions only exposed them." Critically examine.
- □□ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.

MAINS ANGLE

These are model content points; arrange them into paragraphs rather than reproducing a list.

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) -> 15-mark answer

HIGH

Solved 20-Mark Practice

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Critically examine The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) with reference to its concepts, applications and limitations.

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE**1. Concept**

Define the exact scope and terminology.

V

2. Core analysis

Organise the source content into two or three dimensions.

V

3. Evidence

Use the chapter's India-centric examples or chronology.

V

4. Critical layer

Add traps, limitations, counter-view or implementation constraints.

V

5. Judgement

Conclude in direct response to the directive.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
- □ **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
- □ During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
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- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invaded India several times, **1748–1761**.
- □□ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.
- □□ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne)**. The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag □ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
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- □□ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.

MAINS ANGLE

These are model content points; arrange them into paragraphs rather than reproducing a list.

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) -> 20-mark answer

HIGH

Final Consolidated Register Notes

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Final revision is placed after teaching and solved practice.

TOPIC RECALL MAP

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s)

V

Definition □ Aurangzeb's death in 1707 was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.	Mechanism □ Bahadur Shah I (1707–12) followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
Application □ The Sayyid Brothers (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "king-makers" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.	Evaluation □ During Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48), court factionalism continued and provinces such as Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
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- □□ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.

MEMORY HOOK

Meaning -> mechanism -> evidence -> limitation -> judgement

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. ☐ ☐ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne).** The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag ☐ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
2. ☐ ☐ "The decline of the Mughal Empire was rooted in internal structural weaknesses; foreign invasions only exposed them." Critically examine.
3. ☐ ☐ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.
4. ☐ ☐ How did the political vacuum of the 18th century shape the rise of regional states and the eventual **British ascendancy**?
5. ☐ Bipin Chandra frames decline as **structural**, not merely a matter of "bad kings": the **jagirdari and agrarian crisis** was central. The number of nobles (mansabdars) and their claims outran the supply of revenue-yielding **jagirs**, producing a scramble (*be-jagiri*) that turned the nobility inward against itself and against the peasantry.
6. ☐ ☐ Historiography (context to know): **Satish Chandra** located the crisis in the jagirdari–agrarian system; **Irfan Habib** stressed the **agrarian crisis** (over-exploitation of peasants driving revolts); the **Aligarh school** emphasised systemic economic strain, while a **regional/"revisionist" view** (Muzaffar Alam, C.A. Bayly) reframed 18th-century "decline" as a **shift of power and prosperity to the regions**, not universal collapse.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.
- CORRECT:** It **fragmented gradually** over decades; the emperor remained a symbolic figure into the 19th century.
- WRONG:** Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.
- CORRECT:** He **plundered and left**; he did not annex the empire.
- WRONG:** The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.
- CORRECT:** They were **powerful nobles/king-makers**, not rulers.
- WRONG:** Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.
- CORRECT:** They became **autonomous in practice** while nominally acknowledging the emperor.

MAINS ANGLE

Use *The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s)* as an argument, not as an unstructured list of facts.

STUDY LINK

Modern Indian History -> The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s)